



Chef's Table
at Brooklyn Fare



DAVID SHAW
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TARTELETTE

Smoked Salmon from Faroe Island | Trout Ikura | Shiso Flower

WAGYU TARTARE

A5 Miyazaki Wagyu Tartare | Crispy Needle Kelp | Chives | Fish Mousse

SCALLOP

Scallop from Maine | Fried Nori | Koshihikari Rice | Ginger | Shiso Leaf

CAVIAR

Kaluga Caviar | Fish Mousse | Bluefin Tuna | Tomato Tartare
Tomato Dashi Jelly | Chives | Potato Croutons

UNI

Hokkaido Uni | Black Truffle Mousse | Brioche

HAMACHI

Hamachi from Ishikawa | Myoga Ginger | Fish Bone Marrow Sauce
Daikon Radish | Basil Oil | Hojiso | Sun-dried Tomato

MUSHROOM CAPPUCINO

Wood Ear Mushroom and Chanterelle Mushroom | Mushroom Custard
Foie Gras | Burgundy Escargot

MADAI

Madaï from Kyushu | Vin Jaune Sauce with Herb Oil
Shimeji Mushroom | Sepia from Spain

DUCK

Duck from Pennsylvania | Speck Ham | Maitake
Honey Quince Purée | Duck Jus | Red Cabbage

PALATE CLEANSER

Fresh Tangerine | Yogurt Sorbet | Finger Lime Rosé Gel

TIRAMISU SOUFFLÉ

Frozen Soufflé | Cocoa Powder | Mascarpone Cocoa Custard | Espresso Gelato

HOJICHA CAKE

Sponge Cake Soaked in Hojicha | Milk Mousse

PETIT FOURS

Sugar Tea Cake | Caramel Chocolate Tart | Traditional Madeleine



TARTELETTE

The degustation journey at Chef's Table at Brooklyn Fare unfolds on a tartlet, just like last time. On a crispy crust rests smoked salmon from the Faroe island topped with trout roes and shiso flower. The salmon from Faroe island is always known for top quality, and the light smoky tone wafts from the flesh underscores the rich umami of the salmon with a robust yet refined sensation. As the first bite of a winter menu, the chef takes a rather refreshing approach by further enriching the salmon with a vinaigrette that showcases a perfect balance of sweetness and acidity. When it combines with the subtle oceanic brininess that explodes from the trout roe, a trilogy of flavors is composed, coating the tongue with an aura. The shiso flower then offers a final hint to the medley with its mesmerizing herbal refreshingness.

MIYAZAKI WAGYU

Probably the most significant change in the menu setting is the removal of the A5 Miyazaki wagyu course. While the restaurant still offers the dish as a supplement, it is unlikely that it is worth a two-hundred-dollar addition to the bill. Though the removal means we are paying more to get less, it actually makes more sense, as the final main course tends to be a burden for many stomachs. The Miyazaki wagyu now appears in its most pristine form as a tartare bite at the front list of the menu. The tartlet centered on the Miyazaki wagyu tartare is simplistically seasoned with chives and a touch of smoky fish mousse to magnify the pure fantasy of the A5 wagyu. Radiating a tsunami of rich buttery unctuousness and a most sophisticated flavor profile, the charm of the A5 wagyu is unparalleled. A crowning touch of the crispy needle kelp further brings a new level of texture and flavor to the whole.





MAINE SCALLOP

Deviating from the last bites of richness, the next dish arrives in a familiar setting as a gunkanmaki sushi topped with sashimi. The sushi comprises a piece of Maine scallop and a crispy yaki nori that envelops the koshihikari rice. Stuffed with gari sushi ginger, shiso leaf, and scallion, the nearly unseasoned rice lacks a certain degree of umami that could be obtained from an addition of rice vinegar and shoyu sauce. The shiso leaf provides such a strong umeboshi flavor that not only causes a loosening of the balance of the flavor profile but almost turns the sushi into an umeboshi onigiri. The Maine scallop carries a fresh sweet flavor at the price of missing unctuousness and umami that could be the most crucial elements to level up the sushi rice, resulting in the inferiority of this sushi in comparison to the Aji one I had last time.

CAVIAR

While the scallop dish reserved its sushi shape from last time, the caviar dish hasn't changed much as well. Similarly to what we had last year, the bowl consists of a scoop of caviar nestles on top of a core of diced bluefin tuna and fresh tomato flesh bathing in a soothing medley of fish mousse and tomato dashi jelly. The bluefin tuna and tomato flesh are both light and refreshing in a way that won't satisfy the mouth with richness, yet they pave the way for our protagonist, the caviar, to fully shine underneath the spotlight. The jelly form of the tomato dashi provides the medley with a more condensed tomato water flavor while avoiding over-moisturizing the mousse. Opposed to the caviar bowl oozing rich umami that immediately fascinates my palate using the oyster-veal combination, this dish eventually wins my praise by revealing the divine purity of the caviar without the interference of any robust flavors.





UNI TOAST

As the unquestionable *pièce de résistance* of chef César Ramirez, the uni brioche dish has occupied the menu for over a decade. The joyfulness that diners get from this dish is simple: A generous pile of the rich, buttery, and tropically sweet uni on top of a butter-bathed fresh brioche base. Nobody is able to resist ambrosia in such pure form. For dishes like this, the most crucial thing is arguably the quality of the uni *per se*. Unfortunately, this batch of Hokkaido uni turns out as a huge disappointment. The moment it touches my mouth, it coats the tongue with neither the buttery texture nor the dreamy sweetness. Instead, a most unpleasant fishy brininess intrudes on my taste buds. The innovation of the presentation of the truffle, nevertheless, is a remarkable improvement. By changing the truffle slice to truffle purée, the remarkable earthy aroma can now instantly penetrates the whole amalgamation, singing in perfect harmony with both the brioche and the uni.



HAMACHI

The sashimi dish is in a similar design to last time. The hamachi sashimi from Ishikawa is engulfed in a light fish bone marrow consommé augmented with myoga ginger, shiso flower, basil oil, daikon radish, and sun-dried tomato. A bright and promising sweet herbal perfume of basil oil wafts from the plate even before it lands on the counter. Encapsulating the whole in its aromatic cloud, the basil oil is overwhelming that casts a shadow on the pure umami of the sashimi. The duo of myoga and shiso flower cleans off the strong scent and elevates the sashimi with a delicate zen flavor profile while the bone marrow consommé acts as an adhesive that amalgamates the whole with a light yet creamy base. The maple-leaf-shaped Daikon radish does provide subtle flavors, yet it is more of a presentation to me. As for the sun-dried tomato, it carries a unique bright acidity and condensed sweetness, but its necessity should be questioned.

MUSHROOM CAPPUCCINO

Despite the ongoing foie gras ban in New York City, most of the fine dining places are still able to get foie gras to satisfy epicureans. The next mushroom and foie gras soup dish consist of both wood ear and chanterelle mushroom, foie gras, and burgundy snail, all bathing in a rich base of mushroom custard and soup. The double richness of the custard and the foie gras provides a warm bed for the earthy umami to shine. Burgundy snail, though almost invisible, does introduce another layer of umami to the whole. The soup base, however, is unfortunately over-salted, which seems to be a common problem for this soup dish as many diners have complained about it.





MADAI

The main fish dish, again, mostly maintained its old design. The madai fish from Kyushu island is torch-grilled on an open fire in the traditional Japanese manner. Hence the extra crispy skin with a burning fiery aroma. The high temperature soon allures out the fat inside the flesh while retaining its moisture at best, resulting in a delicate interior that reads juicy and flavorful. The texture of madai under the heating process is hard to maintain an extreme tenderness, and a light degree of dryness is thus both understandable and forgivable. Drenched with a trending white vin jaune sauce and herbal oil combination, the flesh is further elevated by the rich umami divulged from the sauce base and the shimeji mushroom. The sepia, on the other hand, offers an intriguing sticky texture to the whole.



DUCK

The duck dish, now marking the finale of the savory part of the menu, is executed with extra ingenuity. Duck is a fabulous protein that always goes well with sweet condiments like honey or orange glaze, as seen in many traditional French duck dishes. Here the duck breast is paired with an innovative sweet-savory twist of refined briny speck ham and delicate honey quince purée. The speck ham, on the one hand, offered an additional layer of depth and salinity that lift the umami of the duck. The quince purée, on the other hand, showcases a ripe orchard fruitiness reminiscent of a mixture of apple, pear, and honey that elevates the duck to another dimension. Grilled smoky maitake and red cabbage, joined by an elixir of duck jus, intertwine the whole with additional layers of flavors and textures.



TIRAMISU SOUFFLÉ

Sharing its notorious fame with the uni brioche dish, the frozen soufflé must be another reason many diners choose to dine for. While most of the frozen soufflé desserts in history are flavored with either light Japanese tea flavors, namely sobacha or matcha, or refreshing fruits like banana and strawberry, the chef tries to impress guests with a breakthrough this time. Unfortunately, it turns out to be quite a disappointment, echoing the failure of the previous uni dish. The frozen soufflé base carries such a unique and light texture. It is so delicate that only works well with flavors that are on the light and refreshing side. A chocolate and coffee-based dessert is usually expected to be rich and creamy, which explains the awkwardness here. The chocolate flavor couldn't combine well with the frozen soufflé base, and the mascarpone cream sauce and espresso gelato are excessively heavy and condensed, resulting in a loss of equilibrium.

PALATE CLEANSER

While most people are only looking forward to the infamous frozen soufflé dessert, they rarely know that the pre-dessert at Chef's Table at Brooklyn Fare is bewitching on its own, proposing another great dish for diners to be anticipated about. While a palate cleanser is a simple bite to clean the palate and bring freshness to prepare for the main dessert, chef Ramirez shows us how he can execute a complex flavor bomb within a limited range. In this small bowl, the mellow and sweet tangerine flesh is paired with a velvety yogurt sorbet and finger lime gelée that carries a fascinating citrusy aroma and rosé-like flavor, brimming my mouth with a most delicate veil of flavors that resemble a splash of white moonlight.





MILK TEA CAKE & PETIT FOURS

The final desserts include a milk tea cake for two and a petit fours trio of caramel chocolate tart, sugar tea cake, and vanilla Madeleine. Soaked in hojicha tea, the sponge cake center of the milk tea cake reveals a heavenly refined and delicate texture that is way more interesting than the pure mousse cake we had last time. The sponge part is enveloped in a light-textured milk curd that resembles panna cotta but with a more refreshing and delicate flavor. The caramel chocolate tart is great to begin with, but the sugar tea cake is just too mediocre to enjoy. Freshly out from the oven, the vanilla Madeleine is executed to such a high level of finesse that the inside is almost as fluffy as a soufflé, regardless of the traditional flavor profile that makes it less attractive.







